

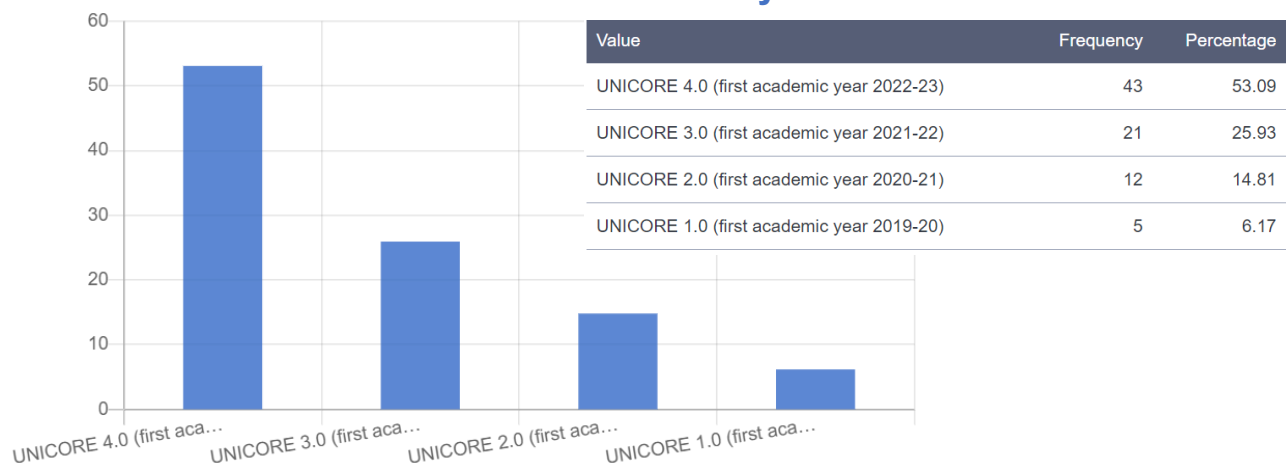
UNICORE SURVEYS

Students, Universities and Local Partners

UNICORE 1.0-4.0 surveys have been conducted in order to better understand **where UNHCR meeting** refugee students, universities and local partners' **needs and where we have opportunities to improve** and to strengthen the way we engage and collaborate focusing on **participation, level of appreciation and empowerment**.

UNHCR launched two concurred surveys, **Students** and **Universities & local Partners**, at the beginning of February 2023 and they run 5 working days. The target groups were **students (103), universities (38) and local partners** - invited by the universities - from the 4 editions of the project.

Students' Survey



81 students (**83,4% of invitees**) contributed to the survey representing the 4 UNICORE's editionsⁱ.

They expressed a good level of appreciation of the project reporting 6 to 8 points' average concerning the main phases of the projectⁱⁱ and comfort of the physical environment. Students shared concerns for the **documentation (TD, visa, residence permit, etc.) (37)**, **financial support (21)** and **dissemination (16)** of the project through the refugee population, as main areas of improvement for the project, followed by support in the **integration in the receiving community (15)**, **academic and orientation tutorship (14)** and **psychosocial support (12)**. In particular *arrive early before class at list it would be extremely important to have one month integration time for the beginning of courses* and need of *Acquiring of Travelling document* have been explicitly mentioned to this end.

Vast majority of responders confirmed to have fully understood the objective of UNICORE and to have received means and resources adequate to carry out their study (61) showing a good level of support and listening in the hosting environment in terms of ease to inform the university and the UNICORE project partners about problems and difficulties encountered in the study or in the inclusion process (67).

However, some students reported delays in receiving the courses material (2) and laptop (1) and to have a weak internet connection (1), impacting on the possibility to study properly.

For what concerns relationships within university and local communities 63 students expressed good level of appreciation while 3 reported to not agree (2) and strongly not agree (1), while remaining neutral in 15 cases. In particular, it has been observed that *There is no good cooperation in the university with the colleagues, the cooperation is very low, because they don't approach you as a new person, it is an individual who have to approach* (1).

The state of conflictuality and in particular the perception of **bully dynamics** and unfair behaviors against refugee students has been perceived by 12 responders (9 agree, 3 strongly agree), complementing with further details reporting rudeness from local partner operators (1), specific bully episodes (3) and discriminatory language and attitudes in the residencies where students are accommodated and employing institutions.

In 50 cases students reported to feel properly involved in decisions process concerning their stay in Italy, while in the remaining cases they reported neutrality (23), to disagree (5) and to strongly disagree (3). Some of them highlighted the need to be involved in ad hoc meeting; to be assisted in the asylum procedure and to be informed about post-graduation possibilities.

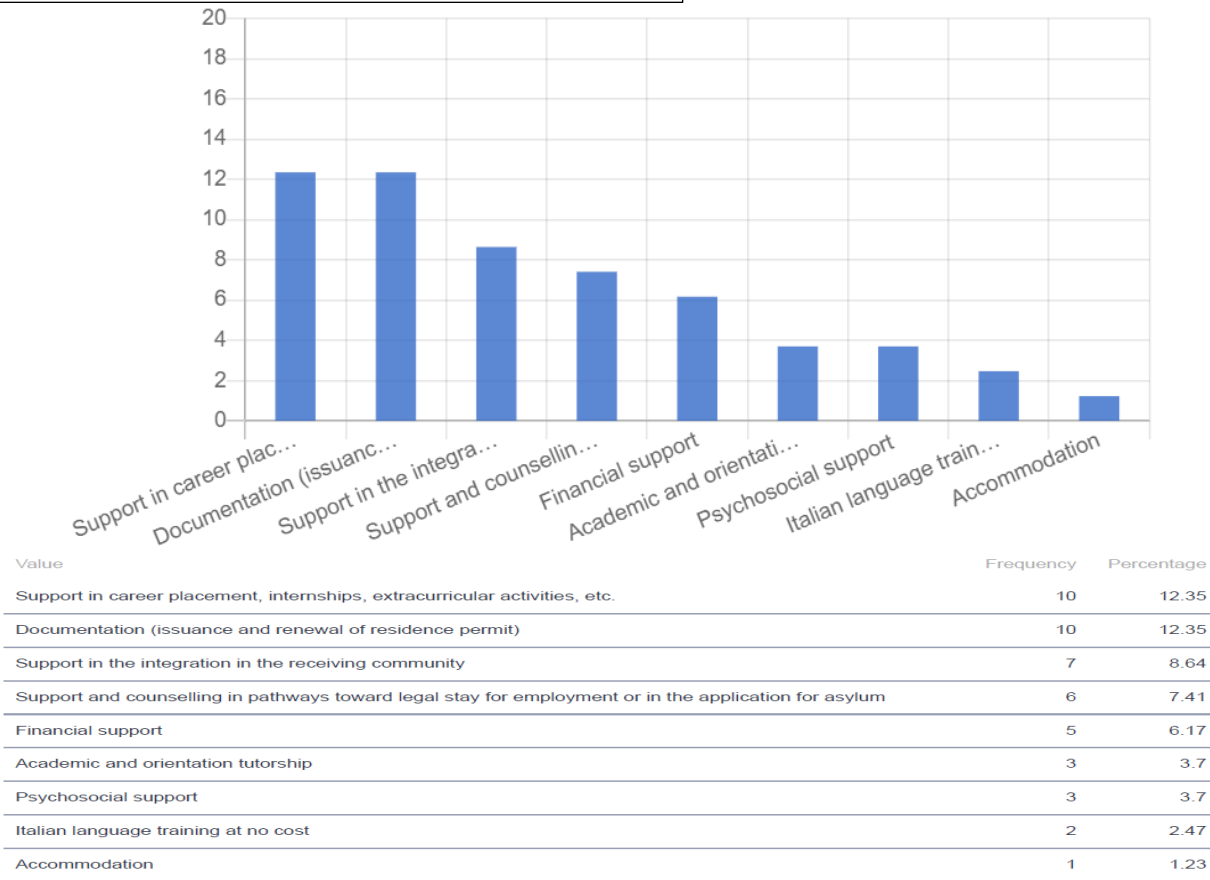
For what concerns UNICORE 4.0 students, they showed good level of appreciation on information received on the terms of the project and of the scholarship's opportunity, provided in a clear, accessible and exhaustive way (40 out of 43).

In 79 cases (out of 81) UNICORE students would recommend this opportunity to other refugees seeking scholarship opportunities in the future and 80 would recommend the expansion of UNICORE projects to other countries in Europe, showing a significant overall level of appreciation for the project.

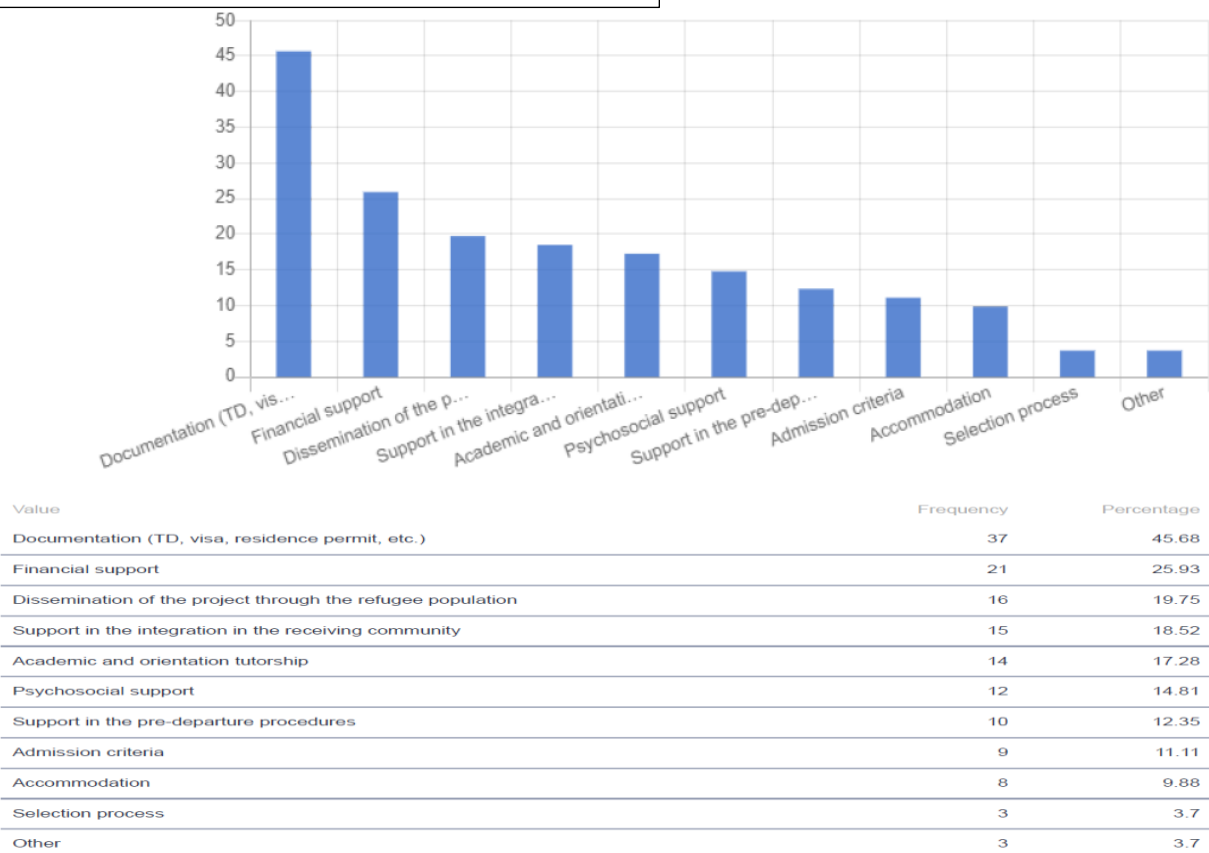
It's worth to note that the survey showed to be an important collector of input provided by the students in particular for what concern the proposal to create a UNICORE students' committee (36 comments), in order to strengthen the participation and involvement of students in the project, and general consideration and suggestion to ameliorate the project (43 comments).

Students expressed preference in starting **consultation for the committee** through a Teams' call and they reported the need to further explore possibilities to ensure their regular involvement for instance combining an annual in presence meeting with regular on-line consultations, including Whatsapp group, and implementing a representation system involving one student from each region where UNICORE scholarships are offered. The committee has been also considered in terms of facilitating the dissemination of information within the concerned refugee population in order ensure that potential eligible candidates have effective access to relevant information, selection process and transparent procedures. The committee has been also proposed to support the orientation of new selected students to facilitate their inclusion in Italy and in general to actively contribute to the decision-making process of the refugee students' population interested in continuing their studies with UNICORE.

UNICORE 1.0 – 2.0 Students - Areas of improvement



UNICORE 3.0 – 4.0 Students - Areas of improvement



Main areas for improvements indicated in the final commentsⁱⁱⁱ mainly reflects those expressed in the first part of the survey and related the need to enhance a participatory approach through a **committee, accommodation services, post-graduation options, difficulties in getting documentation in the pre-departure and post-arrival phases, cooperation with UNHCR staff abroad and possibility to expand the project in the future.**

Universities and partners' Survey

This survey has been submitted to 38 UNICORE Universities asking them to further share it with their local partners-other than the territorial branches of Caritas Italiana, Diaconia Valdese and Centro Astalli that carried out the survey exercise separately.

49 respondents contributed to the survey representing the 4 UNICORE's editions and including the abovementioned 39 Universities (103% of invitees) along with 10 local partners, as follows:



They expressed a good level of appreciation of the project reporting that their expectations on UNICORE have been met (41 cases - 86% of the responders). For what concerns coordination and consultation 45 and 31 responders (91% and 63% of participants) deemed respectively the conduction of coordination meeting to be effective and one-on-one consultations with UNHCR to be ensured as per need. 6 responders (6%) provided suggestions for alternative ways to ensure regular participation of students in the relevant phases of the project including: webinars **including applicants and UNICORE students from previous editions** to share their experience and operational suggestion; involvement of UNICORE students **in local students' association** to facilitate their inclusion; to collect UNICORE students' evaluation and expectations across universities to **test how different partnerships and local organizations differ in their (e.g. students') perception** and how to improve their effectiveness; to organize a **yearly meeting** hosting all students and partners to talk about challenges and outcomes.

For what concerns information provided by UNHCR, 42 responders (86%) confirmed that training and relevant communication are regularly and comprehensively provided and for 36 of them (73%) means and resources are adequate to carry out UNICORE's core phases (e.g. Project design, Protocol and application, Selection, Pre-departure, Arrival, Post-arrival). According to 41 responders (84%) it is possible to easily inform UNHCR about problems and difficulties encountered during the project's process (listening and support indicator).

As regards the quality of ongoing relationships within the project 45 survey's participants (92%) reported that there is a good level of cooperation among UNICORE partners and in 37 cases (76%) to feel themselves involved in decisions process concerning UNICORE.

They expressed an average level of appreciation of the project reporting 5 to 8 points' average concerning the main phases of the project^{iv}. Responders shared concerns for the **post-graduations' opportunities** (e.g. traineeships and job opportunities), **and identification of countries of departure** has been identified as the main area in need of improvement followed by project's dissemination in the country of first asylum, language training, pre-departure information, online pre-departure meeting between students / universities / local partners and travel from asylum country to receiving country^v.

Universities involved in the provision of pre-departure on-line Italian courses reported a high level of appreciation for the different phases concerning the course, suggesting an earlier planning of the classes.

Further useful narrative inputs have been provided, in particular **regarding enhancement of dissemination, affective access of relevant number of eligible refugee students to the selection process, Italian language classes, coordination among universities during the selection process, MAECI engagement, post-graduation, integration once in Italy.**^{vi}

Concluding remarks

Both surveys show a good level of appreciation for the UNICORE project as regards quantitative and qualitative aspects concerning **participation, level of appreciation and empowerment.**

However, there are a range of different expectations and needs that were captured in the surveys' results. In particular, considering the significant number of narrative inputs shared by the **refugee students**, it emerges a strong willingness to actively participate to the different phases of the project in order to ensure that their views and consideration are further taken into consideration and in a perspective of continuous amelioration of the project.

As the results demonstrate, notwithstanding the reported good level of inclusion, it's worth to note that 12 students (over 81) reported perceived bully dynamics and unfair behaviors revealing need of further strengthen efforts at local level to ensure that trusted communication channels with UNICORE beneficiaries are created, reinforced and maintained in order to immediately react on eventual discriminatory behaviors and to fully implement a zero tolerance approach against harassment or discrimination and contribute to enhance a inclusive local society.

It is encouraging that most **universities and local partners** expressed an average level of appreciation for the project. However, it is important to note that most respondents shared concerns regarding countries of departure and pre-departure and post-arrival documentation. Building a further detailed list of criteria in the identification of countries of departure, guided by best practices, lessons learned and relevant

expertise from the regions, can assist with establishing a more solid system cognizant of the needs of UNICORE refugees.

Recommendations

The key recommendation leading from the UNICORE surveys and objectives are related to the main areas observed, as follows:

- Establish a **UNICORE students committee** in accordance with their needs and preferred modalities and in coordination with UNICORE's partners in order to ensure a refugee-centered approach of the project;
- Facilitating necessary **language training** at no cost inter alia for the crucial role played by the language in the inclusion mutual process;
- Facilitating **training to universities and local partners** to improve knowledge and networking with existing inclusion possibilities at local and national level;
- Ensuring that refugee students have access to university or provider services, support, and activities such as career placement, social organisations, internships, extracurricular activities, etc. in order to **ensure a vast spectrum of effective post-graduation options**;
- Providing and/or facilitating access to academic and psychosocial support, where necessary, to encourage student retention, success and to ensure that eventually **discrimination and harassment episodes are properly managed**.

ⁱ The 4 UNICORE students still pending departure from Malawi at the time of surveys' launching will be ensured to participate upon their arrival.

ⁱⁱ Average of appreciation (1-10)

- Dissemination of the project among refugees' community in the country of departure 6
- Ease of navigation/consultation of the website 7
- Clarity of the information provided in the UNICORE website 8
- Clarity of the information provided in each university's call for applications 8
- Ease of the application process (application submission) 8
- Support received during the application phase by Universities, partners, UNHCR 7
- Selection process (interview) 8
- Support received during the pre-departure phase (translation of document to request visa, etc.) 7
- Academic remote tutorship implemented by universities during the pre-departure phases 7
- Italian language course provided by remote 8
- Reception and post-arrival support 8
- Access to documentation (residence permit, enrolment in the National Healthcare system, university enrolment, etc.) 7
- Support from the local organizations (Caritas, Diaconia Valdese, Centro Astalli or others) in facilitating the inclusion process 7
- Support by the university in post arrival academic orientation and tutorship 7

iii **Quotes:** *The initiative taken in the name of "UNICORE" is benevolent and humane enough that it should be mimicked and expanded to other EU member states and may be beyond. It would be far beneficial if similar legal pathways were open to less-skilled protracted*

refugees, too. Life is precious and to spend it in protracted refuge is a curse, thus for me interventions like UNICORE are no less than re-birth in earth and humane.

*The project is a golden opportunity and gave a moral, an ambition and it will bring the tasks of student in to the reality. Therefore Thanks alot. 1. My suggestion is that **regarding the resettlement process of our situation, it is a little bit mixed up and confusion.** So clear information and the other options should be in details. 2. One year **renewal passport**, it took time and time consume, to visit every months to police station and then it valid for 6 months.*

Communication between UNHCR local offices and students has to get improved.

*First to advance the project to **other African countries** Second to advance the project in **other European countries**. Because some students are francophone. may be it will help to them, To benefit the project.*

*The place where I'm living is **far from my university**, I'm finding difficult to meet up with the school program*

*The UNICORE project is such an amazing project that has personally given me hope for the future. However, finding myself here also makes me afraid as to what will be the next step after my graduation. Go back to the refugee camp with my degree? I would like to suggest to the UNICORE leadership to really work hard in terms of advocacy so that we can get **permanent residence in Italy after the completion of our studies**. I know it is not easy to get permanent residence in Italy, but engaging other parties that can facilitate the process of permanent residence for us will assure our stay in Italy.*

*Constant **sensitisation by already beneficiaries of Unicare** students every year to other students yet to be awarded the scholarship in all the countries that Unicare project is supporting. That is like a yearly tour with some Unicare beneficiaries so that those who are yet to benefit will see the proofs talking to them and sharing their experience to them rather than hearing just from the sponsors alone. **because up till date some refugees don't still believe UNICORE to be a reality because it's just like a dream to many as they consider it too prestigeouse to be a reality.** Thanks*

*The UNICORE is a program at the heart refugee empowerment and source of hope for life. So I think, more **information campaigns** should be done to sensitize the refugee communities on how much value it provides. Creation of a campaign committee where beneficiaries of the unicare program spread the information will help and make long lasting impact.*

iv Average of appreciation (1-10)

- Admission criteria 7
 - Selection of countries of asylum/departure 5
 - Dissemination of the project among refugees' community in the country of departure 5
 - Ease of navigation/consultation of the website 7
 - Clarity of the information provided in the UNICORE website 7
 - Clarity of the information provided in your University's call for applications 7
 - Ease of the application process (applications' analysis) 7
 - Selection process (interview) 7
 - Academic remote tutorship implemented by universities during the pre-departure phases 6
 - Reception and post-arrival support 8
 - Capacity to identify local partners and sign local Protocols 8
 - Support from the local organizations (Caritas, Diaconia Valdese, Centro Astalli or others) in facilitating the inclusion process 8
 - Support by the university in post arrival academic orientation and tutorship 8
 - Psychosocial support 7
 - Other (potential area/s for improvement): *Post graduation opportunities, Traineeship and placement opportunities, Language improvements, the promotion of the project in the selected states must be greatly strengthened, also making intensive use of all the associations operating in the area to identify candidates.*
- The selection of starting nations must be done well in advance. Support from national partners (Ministry)*

Universities providing Italian language courses (only)

- Criteria to allocate students to each class 8
- Dissemination of the Italian Language training (on-line) among UNICORE students 9
- Ease of on-line participation 8
- Study material provided by your University to students 9
- Clarity of the information provided on modality and schedule of the training 8

- Other (potential area/s for improvement), please describe *have the dates for the pre-departure Italian courses earlier during the year rather than later.*

describe *have the dates for the pre-departure Italian*

Local Partners (only)

- Pre-departure on-line orientation sessions 8
- Reception and post-arrival support 8
- Documentation (issuance and renewal of residence permit) 8
- Psychosocial support (if provided) 7
- Legal support (if provided) 8
- Other (potential area/s for improvement), please describe *Preparation of the document before the travel*

^w In need of improvement:

- Programme design 4
- Identification of UNHCR operations abroad 5
- Identification of countries of departure 7
- Identification of universities and partner organizations 4
- Preparation and finalization of the national protocol 5
- Preparation and finalization of the on-line application 5
- Dissemination in the country of first asylum 6
- Applications 5
- Selection process 5
- Admission & publication of the selected candidates 4
- Pre-enrollment procedures 5
- Legal status, travel document and visa application 5
- Language training 6
- Pre-departure information 6
- Online pre-departure meeting between students / universities / local partners 6
- Travel from asylum country to receiving country 5
- Post-arrival and integration 6
- Other, please describe **Higher communication and sharing of experiences** among local partners also across different hosting towns. Higher dissemination involving also other stakeholders to be able to attract female candidates who, also for other reasons, are still severely underrepresented./More direct support/orientation by UNHCR to the students exiting the project, about possible conversion of their permit to other forms (e.g. for those willing to further continue their studies or look for a job in Italy)/evaluation of sending countries also taking into account the easyness of obtaining **travel documents** (avoid countries from which ETD are hard to obtain OR need to then be changed/renewed once in Italy)./More time for the **project-design** phase/Possibility to have a **specific agreement with CIMEA/ A better coordination among universities for the first/ second ... choices** of selected students/ **Trianing Opportunities** for the University staff Official events that involve the university governance (invitation to the deens for the national protocol..)/Improve the coordination with other national / international network and with other subjects involved in **humanitarian corridors/ we have had problems with some local partners**, as you know

^{vi} Work together to reduce the risk to have few or not eligible candidates: early identification of countries of origin to better define the appropriate academic offer; wider dissemination in the countries of first asylum, underlining also the importance of a good Italian language knowledge for a better integration in Italy; better coordination among universities during the selection process; reflect on the problems that may arise if selected students fail to proceed with the studies on time. National protocol and engagement of the Ministry should be defined in advance.

UNICORE is a great project that opens new horizons to underprivileged students. As in all human activities, the project may be improved but is already "algebraically" a great PLUS. One aspect that definitely deserves further care is the post-graduation phase of the students, in particular for what concerns their status and documents

As a volunteer of a local partner, I felt the integration aspect is the point that most needs improvement, but we do have to consider the two years of pandemic which did not socialize us much. Even so, I still think that a program should be made to help with integration.